UNWISE WORDS



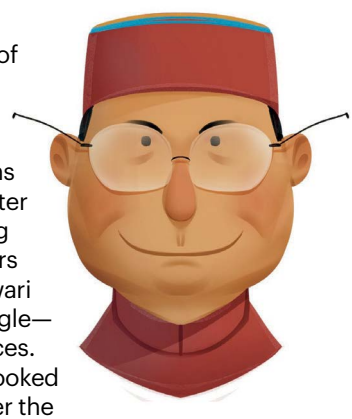
Politics thrives on words, and missteps. Gujarat BJP chief **Jagdish Vishwakarma** managed to turn a victory speech for the sweeping local body wins into a controversy. His reference to power slipping from the "*pallu*" of Congress MP **Geniben Thakor** is now being parsed for tone, intent and gender sensitivity. Vishwakarma insists the remark was political, not personal. Thakor and the Congress are having none of it, and have called for protests. Meanwhile, the Thakor community itself appears to be weighing its response, for now.

FUTURE GAZER



Tej Pratap, Lalu Prasad's estranged elder son, seems to have rediscovered his political nous months after the defeat in the assembly poll. With his outfit, the Janshakti Janata Dal, getting little traction, and brother Tejashwi Yadav showing little inclination to reopen the doors of the Rashtriya Janata Dal, Tej is exploring other options. So, one day, he gets dad Lalu over to cut his birthday cake, on another, he's at Jan Suraaj chief Prashant Kishor's doorstep, confabulating on the "shape of future politics". The latest is a video call with the seer Baba Bageshwar, where he asks him to "see my political future". As things stand, that might be a prediction too difficult for even the baba to make.

WILD IDEA



A wedding in the core area of the Rajaji Tiger Reserve has put Uttarakhand's forest department in a spot. The grand preparations for the nuptials of BJP minister **Khajan Das**'s son—including industrial generators, coolers and a full pandal at Sureshwari Devi temple deep in the jungle—sparked a row over clearances. The department has now booked the temple committee under the Wildlife Protection Act and suspended two officials. The minister claimed tacit approval. The wedding ceremony went ahead, though, fully stripped of the frills.

Kaushik Deka **with** ***Jeemon Jacob, Prasad Nichenametla, Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava*** **and** ***Avaneesh Mishra***

ECO WATCH

CONSERVATION DILEMMAS
WILDLIFE VS HUMAN HABITATS

By **Jumana Shah**

In Maharashtra, the proposed exclusion of 17 villages from the ambit of the Sahyadri Tiger Reserve plan has revived a sharp debate. The move, pitched as a way to address local livelihood and relocation concerns, has triggered alarm among conservationists, who argue that it risks undermining the ecological integrity of the region. The area in question is part of a crucial wildlife corridor that allows tigers and other species to move between forest patches in the Western Ghats. Fragmenting this landscape, experts warn, could isolate populations, increase human-wildlife conflict, and open the door to mining and other activity in previously protected zones. The episode illustrates a recurring dilemma in conservation policy—addressing the needs of human settlements that, paradoxically, are themselves endangered by the very wildlife they must co-exist with.



RAJAN JOSHI

In a related matter, the Supreme Court has taken suo motu cognisance of illegal sand mining in the Chambal Sanctuary, a protected riverine stretch spanning Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, noting that it is degrading fragile river habitats critical for endangered species such as gharials and Gangetic dolphins. It has also sought responses from the three state governments, signalling concern over persistent enforcement failures.

In Gujarat, a different kind of contest is unfolding around the Girnar Wildlife Sanctuary in Junagadh district. Religious groups like the Girnar Sanrakshan Samiti want the scrapping of the eco-sensitive zone (ESZ) surrounding the sanctuary, which is home to 54 lions. The Girnar hills host four major pilgrimage sites that attract heavy pilgrim footfalls. ■